

Living with computers

A Computers: friend ...

People who have grown up with PCs and microchips are often called the digital generation. This is how some people answered when questioned about the use of computers in their lives.

'I have a GPS, Global Positioning System, fitted in my car. With this navigation system I never get lost. And the DVD recorder is perfect for my children's entertainment.'

'I use an interactive whiteboard, like a large touchscreen monitor, at school. I find computers very useful in education.'

'Assistive technology, for people with disabilities, has helped me a lot. I can hardly see, so I use a screen reader, a program that reads aloud onscreen text, menus and icons.'

'This new HMD, head-mounted display, allows me to watch films, and enjoy virtual reality, the artificial environment of the latest video games.'

'The upgraded wireless network at my university is great: we can connect our laptops, PDAs and Wi-Fi cell phones to the network anywhere in the campus. Communication is becoming easier and easier.'

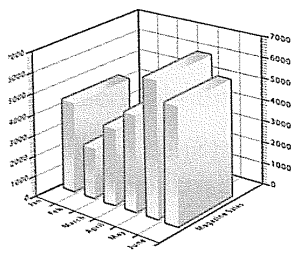
B ... or foe?

- Our society has developed **technological dependence**. When computers are down, our way of life breaks down: planes stop flying, telephones don't work, banks have to close.
- Computers produce **electronic waste**, plastic cases and microchips that are not biodegradable and have to be recycled or just thrown away.
- They are responsible for health problems, e.g. **computer addiction**, an inappropriate and excessive use of computers.
- **Cybercrime**, crime committed with the help of computers, is creating serious problems.
- Citizens may feel a **loss of privacy** because of unauthorized use of personal data or receiving unwanted electronic messages.

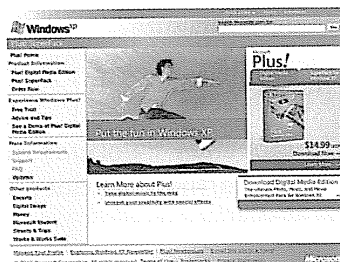
C Things we can do on the computer



A publication



A business graph



Web pages and email

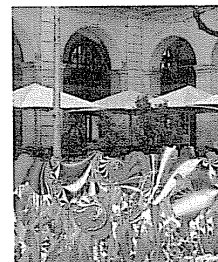


Photo editing

A secretary: 'I use computers to do the usual office things like **write letters** and **faxes**, but what I find really useful is email. We are an international company and I **send emails** to our offices all over the world.'

A publisher: 'We use PCs to produce all sorts of texts in digital format. We **publish e-books** (electronic books) and interactive e-learning programs on CD, and we help a local company to **design an online newspaper**, displayed on the Web.'

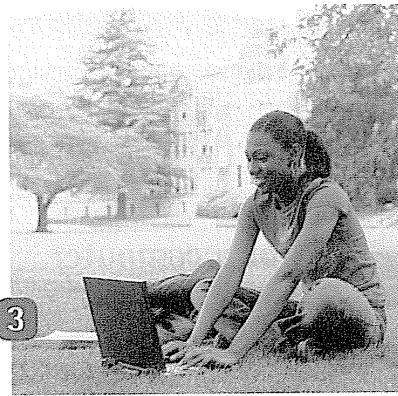
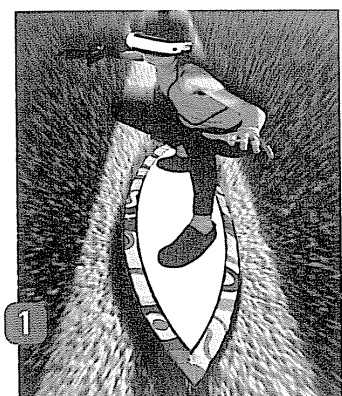
A bank manager: 'We use financial software to **make calculations** and then generate graphs or charts. We also use a database to **store information** so that it can be easily searched.'

A home user: 'I like to **retouch photos** on my computer; I improve them by making a few touches and then save them on a CD. I also enjoy looking at music portals on the Web. I **surf the Web** every day and I often **download files**, I copy music files from the Net to my PC.'

1.1 Complete these sentences with words from A opposite.

- 1 The is a piece of software that interfaces with your PC and allows you, via keyboard commands, to get any text information read to you in synthetic speech.
- 2 A , as popularized by virtual reality, lets the user immerse him/herself in a synthetically generated environment.
- 3 An is a touch-sensitive device where a special pen or your finger can act as a mouse.
- 4 Tony Adams is now the proud owner of a dark silver Vogue, complete with leather interior, navigation, and a with LCD TV screens.

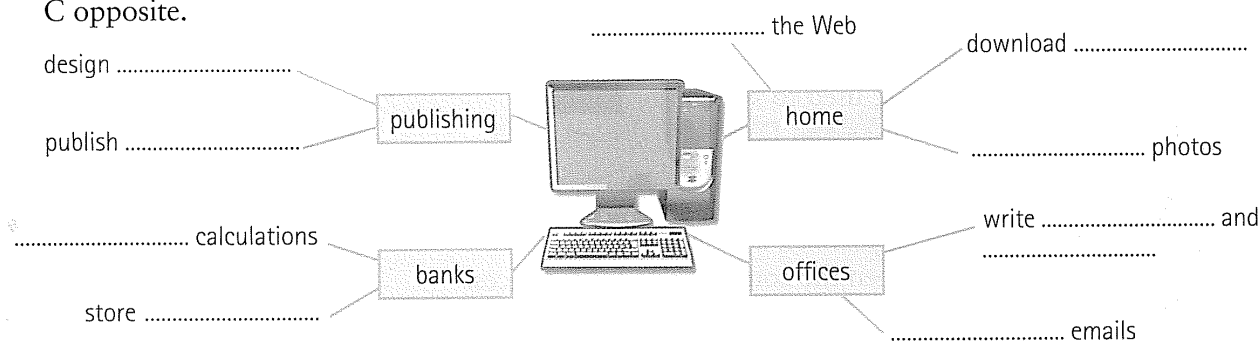
1.2 Which computer use in A do these pictures illustrate?



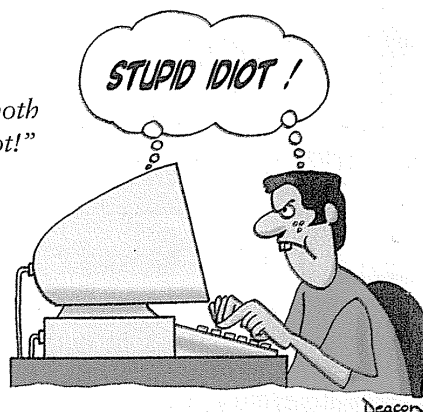
1.3 Read B opposite. What problem do these sentences refer to?

- 1 We are sorry to announce that most flights are delayed or cancelled.
- 2 He should go to a psychologist. He spends hours surfing the Web.
- 3 Technology changes so quickly that we have to scrap computers when they become obsolete.
- 4 I've been getting emails about offers for lots of different products.
- 5 My computer system has been broken into and some useful information has been destroyed.

1.4 Some words often appear together in IT. Complete these computer uses with word partners from C opposite.



Computer and man both thinking "Stupid Idiot!"



You and computers

Make a list of the ways you use computers at work and in your free time.